Fostering a synergy between the development of well-being and musicianship through a movement-based approach to instrumental music learning and teaching

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DESW
Institute of Musicology and the Arts
University of Luxembourg

ISME
July 25-31, 2026

Université du Luxembourg

GHENT UNIVERSITY

SOMETHING ABOUT ME

Musician

Teacher/Educator

Researcher

SOMETHING ABOUT ME

Musician

MA in Music Performance (clarinet)

chamber music & orchestra

Holy 7: Balkan & Klezmer

Teacher/Educator

Teacher diploma (1997) (clarinet, sax, ensemble)

Conservatoires
(The Hague, Amsterdam, Geneva, Lausanne, …)

Experimental ateliers

volunteer work with vulnerable children

Researcher

MA in Philosophy (2008)

PhD in Systematic Musicology (2012)

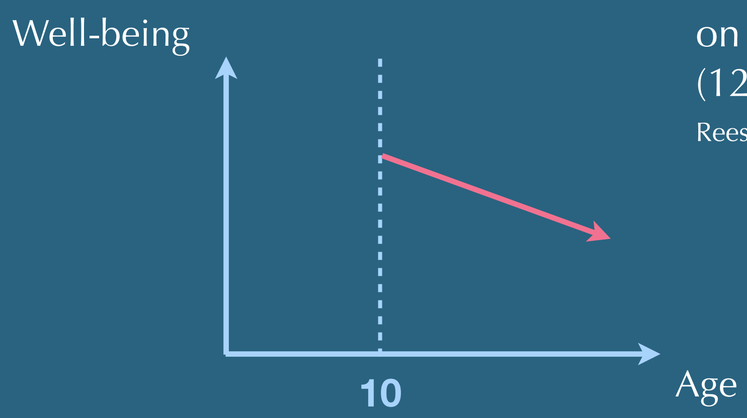
Postdoc

Educational Researcher

Professor

WHY | Promoting well-being

WHY | Promoting well-being



Children's Worlds International Survey on Children's Subjective Well-Being (128,000 children in 35 countries)

Rees et al., 2020

school and school-related variables impact well-being

Huebner et al., 2014; Casas & Gonzalez, 2017

Rees, G. (2017). *Children's Views on Their Lives and Well-being*. Springer.

Huebner, E. S., Hills, K., Jiang, X., Long, R., Kelly, R., & Lyons, M. (2014). Schooling and children's subjective well-being. In A. Ben-Arieh, F. Casas, I. Frønes, & J. E. Korbin (Eds.), *Handbook of child well-being* (pp. 797–819). Springer. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-90-481-9063- 8_26.

Casas, F., & González, M. (2017). School: One world or two worlds? Children's perspectives. *Children and Youth Services Review*, 80, 157–170.

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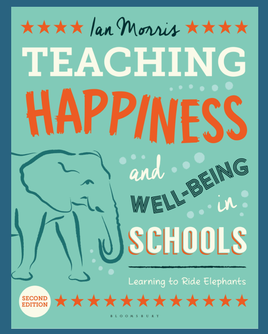


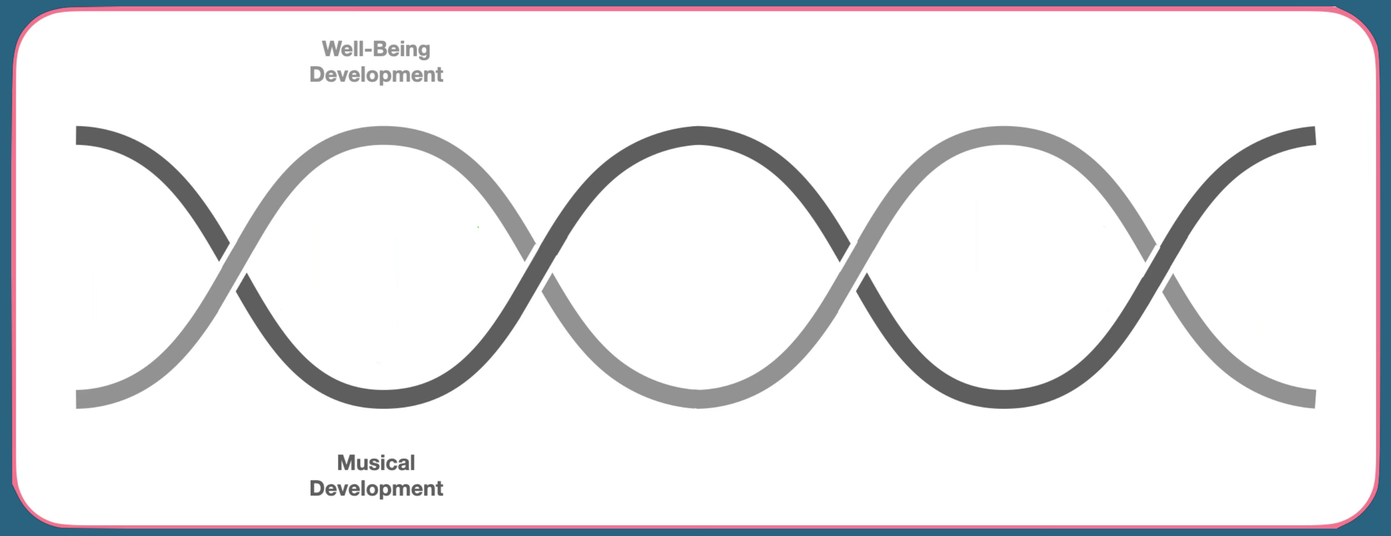
Morris, 2015

Efficiency and Productivity

Well-being

Morris, I. (2015). Teaching happiness and well-being in schools: Learning to ride elephants. Bloomsbury Publishing.

HOW | An eudaemonic stance to Eveil Musical



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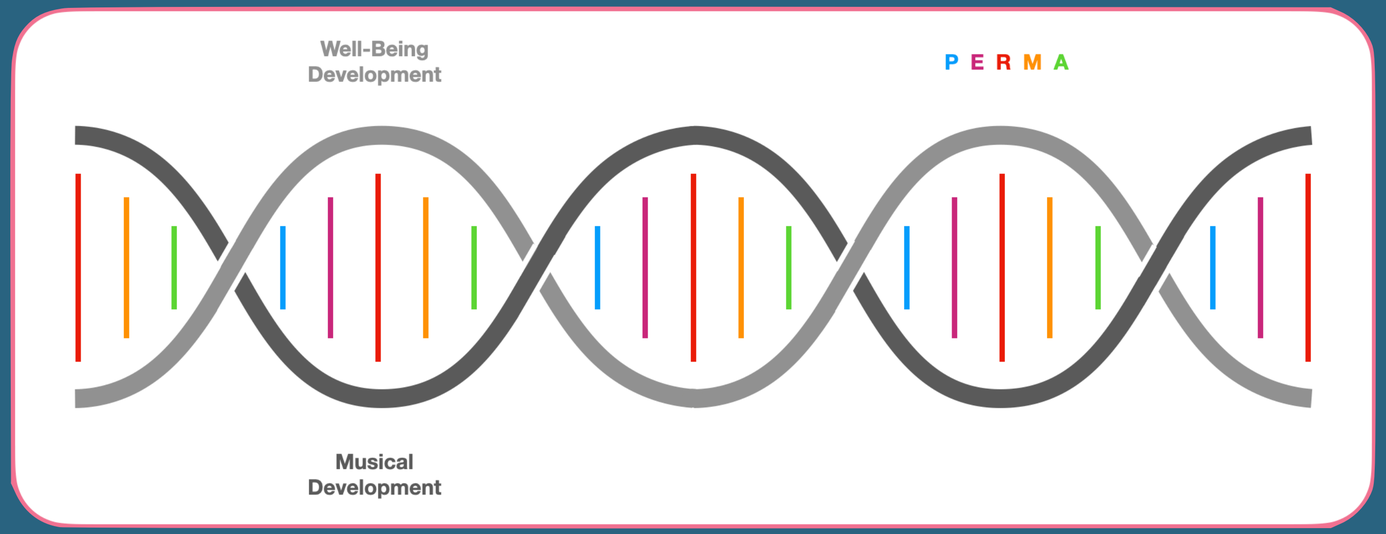

DEVELOPING AN EMBODIED MUSIC PEDAGOGY

This pedagogy acknowledges the fundamental role of learners' and teachers' physical and expressive interaction with music and each other, and is developed for lessons where communication through/with/in sound and music is the dominant mode.

(Bremmer & Nijs, 2022)

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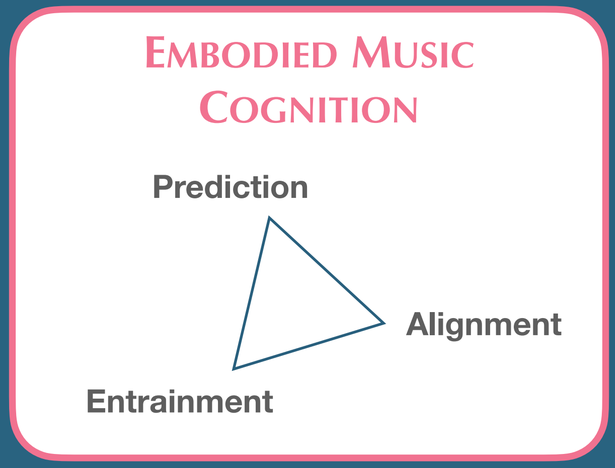

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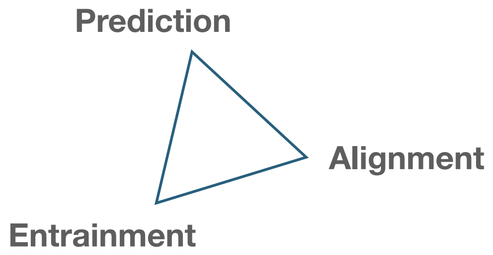
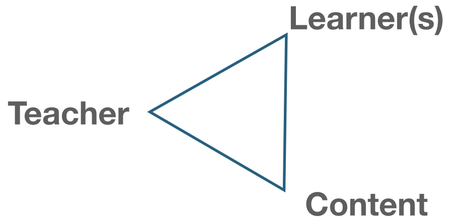
Embodied Music Cognition



Dynamical Systems Theory



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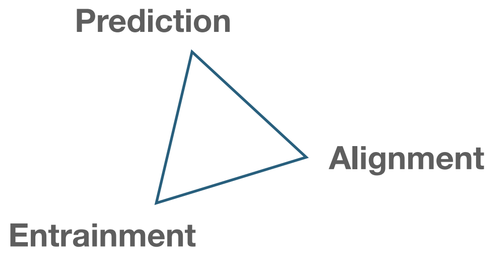

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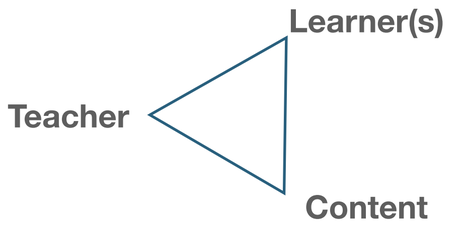
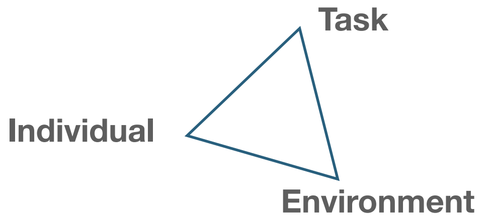


Non-Linear Pedagogy



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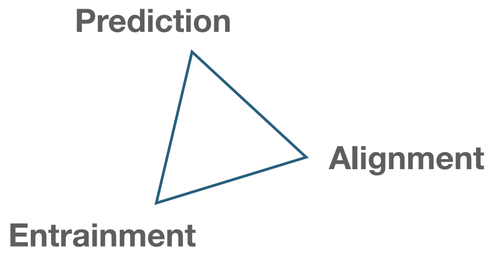

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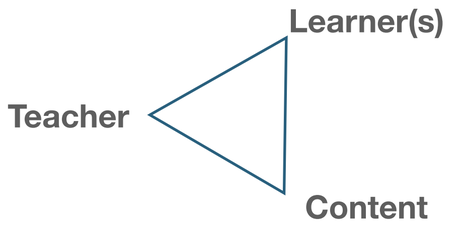

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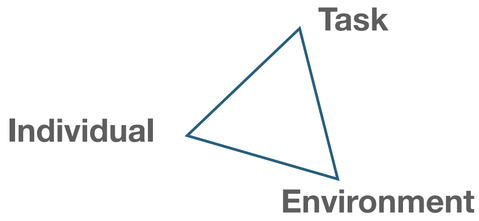

Well-being

Positive Emotion Engagement Relation Meaning Achievement

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EMBODIED MUSIC INTERACTION

3 basic mechanisms

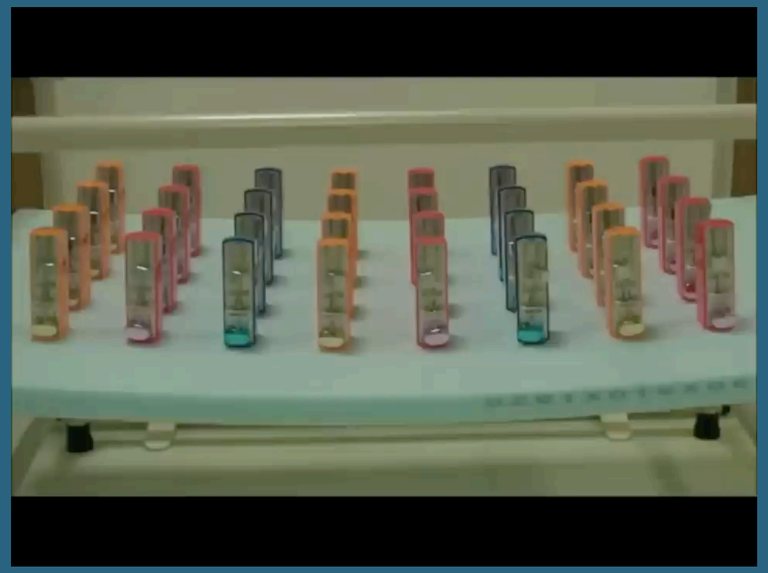
Entrainment

Prediction

Alignment

EMBODIED MUSIC INTERACTION
3 basic mechanisms

Entrainment

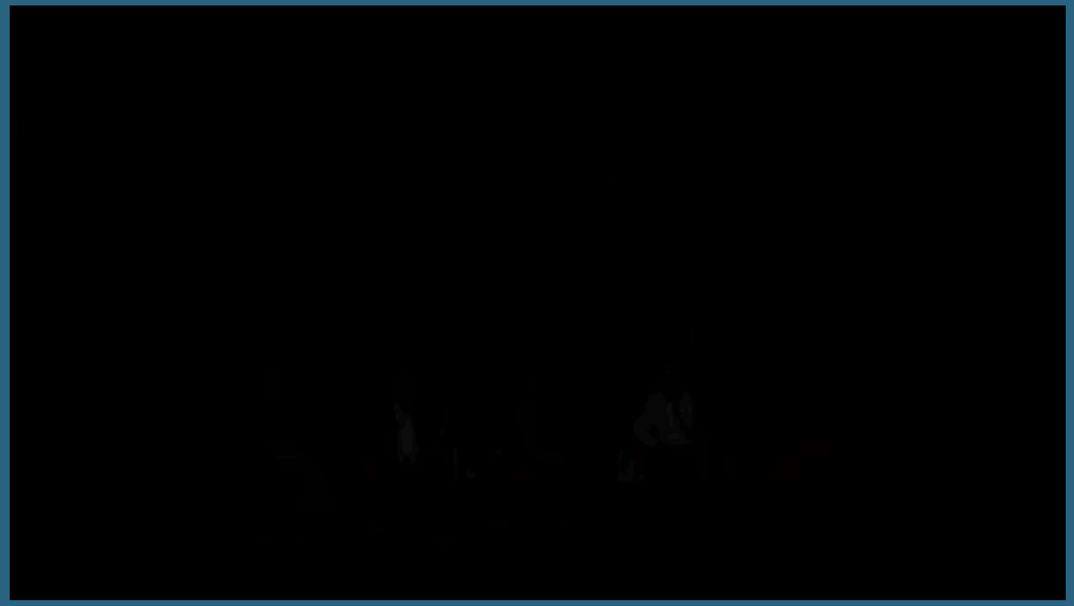


Prediction

Alignment

EMBODIED MUSIC INTERACTION
3 basic mechanisms

Entrainment **Prediction** **Alignment**



EMBODIED MUSIC INTERACTION
3 basic mechanisms

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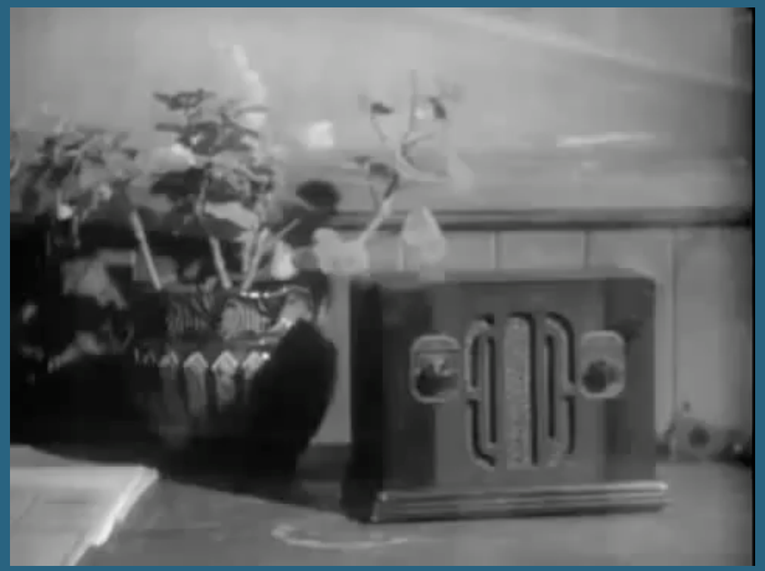


NON-LINEAR PEDAGOGY / CONSTRAINTS_LED APPROACH

Constraint-led pedagogy revolves around the constraints
placed on an individual, shaping or limiting certain their behaviour (Davids, 2012)

Newell (2003) distinguishes between 3 constraints:

- **Individual**: structural (constant) & functional (change)
- **Environmental**: outside the individual body (incl. socio-cultural)
- **Task**: specified by the task to be performed

POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

Seligman, 2011

P Positive emotion

E Engagement

R Relationship

M Meaning

A Achievement

POSITIVE PSYCHOLOGY

Seligman, 2011

P Positive emotion

E Engagement

R Relationship

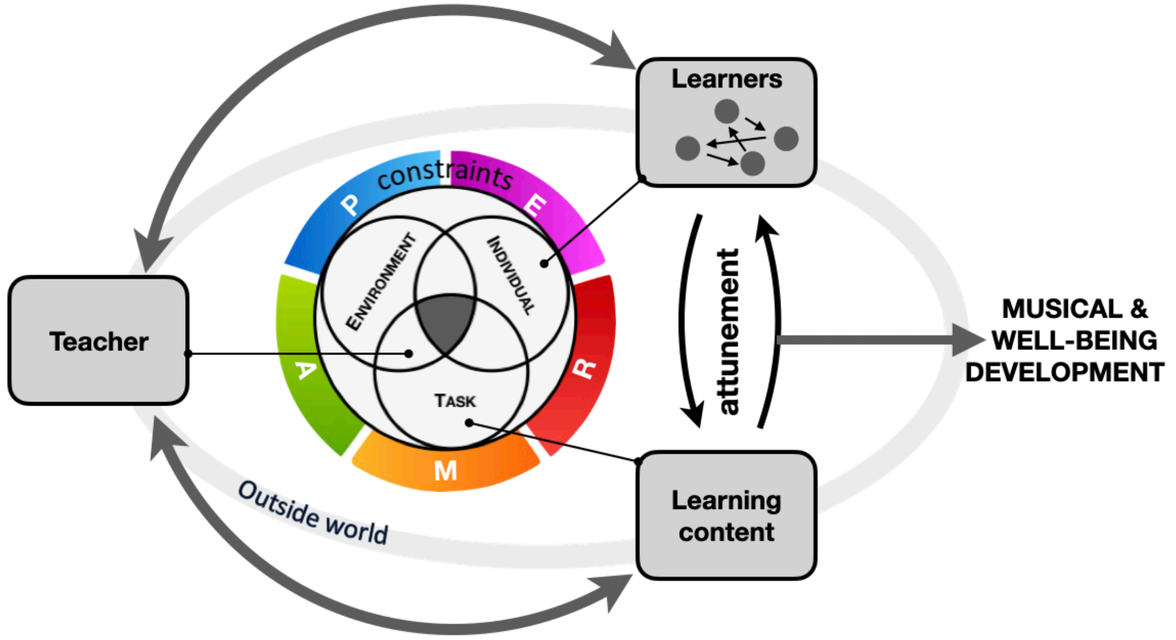
M Meaning

A Achievement

Kern, 2020

H Health

EMBODIED MUSIC PEDAGOGY



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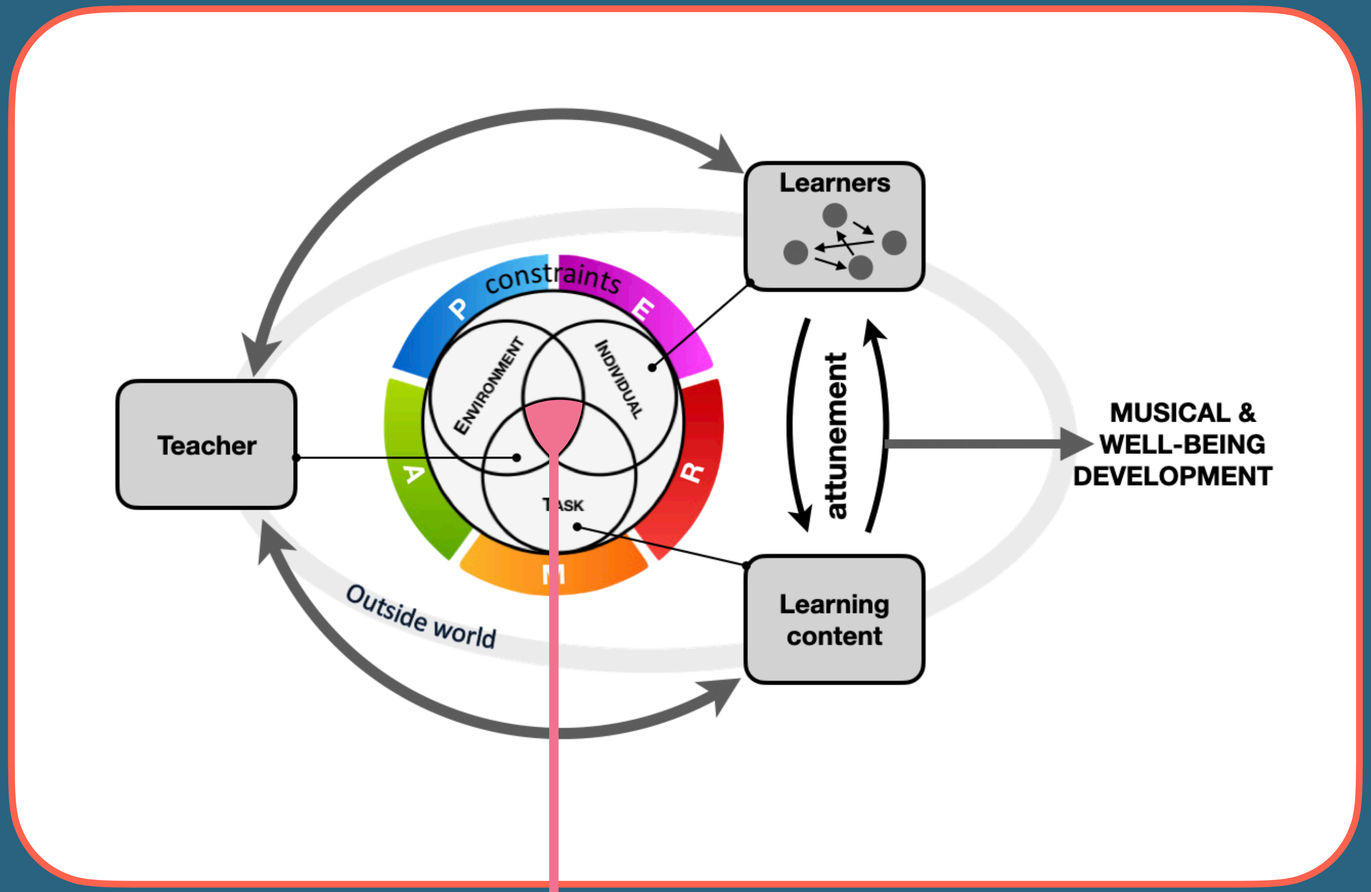

BODY

KINEMUSICAL APPROACH TO INSTRUMENTAL MUSIC LEARNING & TEACHING

reconsider the role of the body and body movement in learning how to play an instrument
“education of the body” that goes beyond a mere instrumentalist approach to body and instrument

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KINEMUSICAL APPROACH

Premises

Developing the inner musician

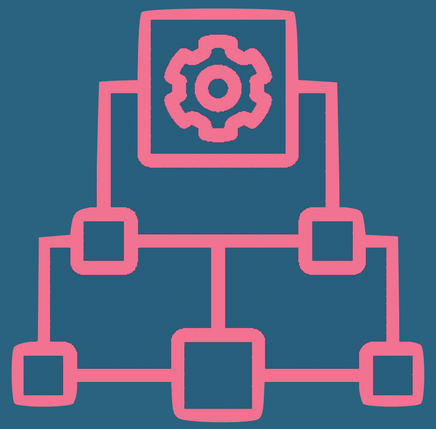
Involving the instrument

Bottom up

From simple to complex

Exercising the performing body

HOW | Design Prompts



Translate theory into practice

Support - educational design
- reflection
- observation
- flexibility
- creativity

Musical Activities

Improvisation
Inventing music. This can be done within a harmonic or melodic framework (e.g. blues, pentatonics), or completely freely.

Performance
Playing existing music (composition, pattern).

Composition
Inventing music and writing it down in a "finished product" that can be played by others. This can be via traditional (stave, notes, etc.) or alternative notation.

Didactic strategies

Switch
At a signal from the teacher or fellow student, the completion of a task changes.

Start-stop
At a signal from the teacher or fellow student, a certain action is stopped or restarted.

Follow the other
One pupil does something, the other follows. This may involve movement, music or a combination of both.

Taking turns
Students take turns playing as in question and answer, finishing a sentence, ...

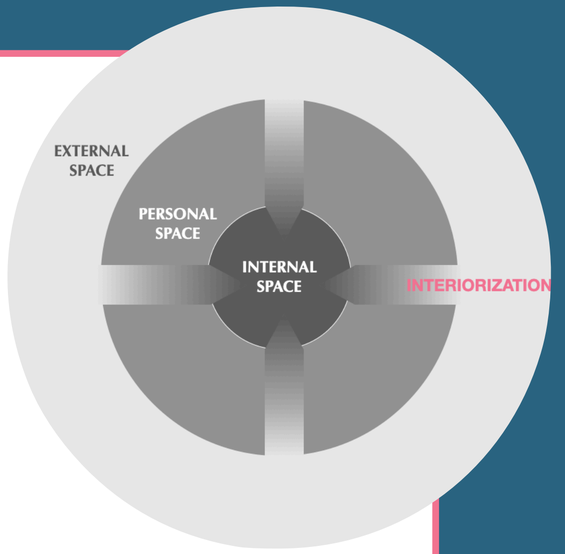
Spaces

External
External space is the space in which one can move around (e.g. the classroom).

Personal
Personal space is the space you can occupy - on the spot - with your body.

Inner
Inner or tactile-kinesthetic space is the space you experience in your body, from movement you feel inside you and from touch.

Spaces



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Spatial choreography

Free
Students move freely, be it on site or in space.

Facing each other
Students face each other and mirror each other's movements. This can be done in pairs or with together more students.

Circle
Students stand in a circle. In large groups, several (concentric) circles can be formed.

In a row
Students stand in a row, be it all next to each other, or all behind each other.

Social Choreography

Individual
Each students works on a task individually.

One-to-one
Students form pairs and perform a task based on a particular strategy, e.g. "Follow the other" or "Take turns".

In small groups
Students form small groups, from 3 to 6 pupils according to the task.

Everyone together
A task is performed by everyone together.

Social interaction

No or little social interaction
Students may perform an exercise together without being invited to interact with each other. For example, they may stand together in a circle and perform a particular exercise without consciously following or influencing each other.

Unidirectional social interaction
Students participate in an activity together in which they are invited to actively interact during the activities. The interaction remains in one direction. For example, one follows the other.

Bidirectional social interaction
Students participate together in an activity in which they are invited to actively interact with each other. The interaction is thus reciprocal and learners influence each other.

Relationship music-movement

Exploratory
Students discover, while experimenting, which movements suit the music (or vice versa) and work with the instrument.

Complementary
The movements add something to the musical focus (e.g. metre) or facilitate an aspect of playing (e.g. feeling the beats).

Aligning
The movements are fully aligned with a musical element, e.g. the melody.

Preparatory
The movements aim to prepare for a particular musical task.
This may involve loosening up the body, rehearsing/automating a particular step pattern, ...

Independent
The movements are independent of the musical

Activity profile

Kinemusical Approach, constraints & PERMA

MEET n’ GREET

In a first part, learners freely walk around (without their instruments) in the classroom. When passing somebody, they shake hands to say hello (no words!). The way of shaking hands is changed on cue, switching between different shape qualifications, namely *shape-flow* (self-directed; handshake without being interested in the other), *directional shape* (spoke-like and arc-like movement that bridges from self to the environment, like a professional handshake), or *shaping* (rich mutual and sophisticated interaction supported by full-bodied interactions, very expressive and somewhat exaggerated handshake as if meeting somebody you like a lot and didn’t see for a long time).

In the second part of the activity, students walk around (with their instrument) and, when passing somebody, they improvise a musical motif on their instrument to say hello in accordance with the different shape levels (uninterested, professional, expressive). Again, the way of musically saying hello is changed on cue

Kinemusical Approach, constraints & PERMA

MEET n' GREET

Manipulate constraints

Individual: level of arousal

Task: different ways of greeting

Environmental: group/dyad

PERMA

P: expressiveness, movement-music

E: skill/challenge

R: changing dyads, reciprocal/affective/observational

M: creative connection music-movement

A: open, reactions

STEP ’n PLAY

Students start stepping together using a specific pattern, often used in folk dance, namely the sideward close step. They are instructed but given some time to find each other’s tempo and synchronize. When they do, the teacher (or peer) gives a cue and part of the students (determined beforehand or by a sign of the teacher) starts playing a whole note (𝅝), at the next cue a next group start playing 2 half notes (𝅗𝅥 𝅗𝅥). A next cue triggers a final group to play 4 quarter notes (♩♩♩♩). On a sign (e.g., explicit gesture), students switch to another pattern. At a certain point, the teacher may invite a student to improvise or play a certain melody.

Kinemusical Approach, constraints & PERMA

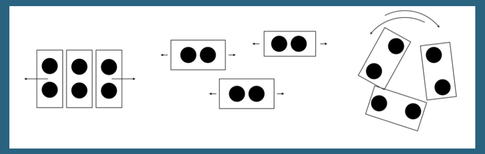
STEP ’n PLAY

Manipulate constraints

Individual: synchronization

Task: stepping patterns, play

Environmental: spatial & social choreography



PERMA

P: expressiveness, movement-music

E: sensorimotor coupling, fluency of performance

R: moving together, I & we-agency

M: basic mechanisms of sense-making

A: find the beat, play while stepping

RFERENCES

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Thank you!

looking forward to your questions, remarks, ...

luc.nijs@uni.lu - unilu.lucnijs.be